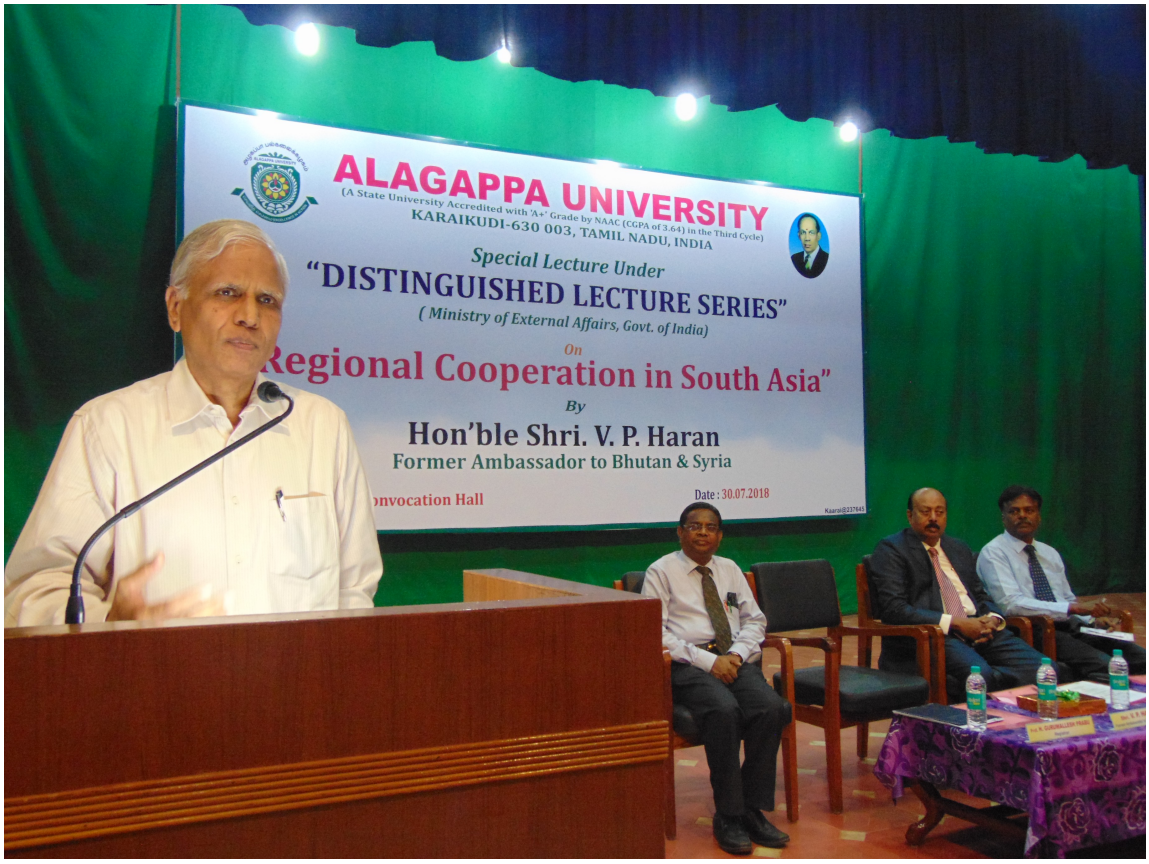
ALAGAPPA UNIVERSITY

(Accredited with "A+" Grade by NAAC (CGPA:3.64) in the Third Cycle & Graded as Category-I University and Granted Autonomy by MHRD-UGC)

KARAIKUDI – 630 003, TAMIL NADU, INDIA

Date: 30.07.2018

Under the Distinguished Lectures Series initiated by the Ministry of External Affairs Shri.V.P.Haran, Former Indian Ambassador to Bhutan and Syria, delivered a lecture at Alagappa University, Karaikudi, on "Regional Cooperation in South Asia".



In his address he said that South Asia was one of the most integrated regions about 70 years back. But the political boundaries drawn in 1947 divided the people and made most inter linkages inoperative making the region one of the least economically integrated regions. In many cases we are now endeavouring to reestablish the earlier linkages with the establishment of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) in 2005. These countries have understood the significance of regional cooperation that will usher in peace, prosperity and stability which are related to developmental issues. This organization acts as a catalyst for accelerating economic growth of the region with increased employment opportunities for people of the

region, reduction in poverty levels and expanding the markets available for a country's products in other SAARC countries. In this era of globalization the speaker insisted on the importance of regional cooperation which would help the member countries to withstand competition and make their products globally competitive.

Dwelling on the success brought in by cooperation among some South Asian countries he said that the pragmatic success of regional cooperation could be seen in the development of power production sector and the extra clean green energy produced is shared by some of the SAARC countries. Successful water-sharing by some of these SAARC countries is another factor to be taken into account owing to successful regional cooperation. He concluded his speech by stating that we can be optimistic about the progress of the regional cooperation efforts in South Asia in the long run, but at the same time that our approach should be realistic keeping in view the political environment.

Presiding over the function Prof.N.Rajendran, Vice-Chancellor of Alagappa University said that the very presence of an eminent Ambassador would inspire the students to opt for higher official positions at the National level and added that it was the first time that the University has arranged a lecture by an Ambassador on foreign affairs for the benefit of students. He stated that Indian Foreign policy is intrinsically connected with Indian ethos. Diplomacy is a delicate balancing and it is not deceit. Basic determinants of foreign policy are protecting national interest, sovereignty, territorial integrity and economic independence. India is looked upon as a leader of decolonized Afro-Asian countries. Besides, India is pioneering cooperation in South Asia region. The perceptible change in India's foreign policy is shift from acrimony to accommodation and regional development. The Vice-Chancellor said that more such lectures would be arranged under the Distinguished Lecture Series by eminent scholars in future.

Prof.H.Gurumallesh Prabu, Registrar, welcomed the gathering, Dr.A.Narayanamoorthy, Member of Syndicate, proposed a vote of thanks. An interactive session was arranged in which Shri.V.P.Haran gave enlightening answers to the students who posed a variety of questions about foreign affairs; and also a separate interactive session for students aspiring for I.A.S., I.P.S., and I.F.S. positions was held at the Seminar hall of the Convocation auditorium.

Prof.H.Gurumallesh Prabu

REGISTRAR